international cricket, I never resorted to short cuts and there was no question of changing that at the start of 2013.

In the Ranji Trophy we beat Baroda and Services on the way to the final against Saurashtra, which we won by an innings and 125 runs. Mumbai then took on the Rest of India in the Irani Cup game, in which I got a hundred. It was an innings that gave me a lot of satisfaction and confidence going into the Test series.

We started the first of four Tests against Australia on 22 February at the Chepauk in Chennai, one of my favourite grounds. Australia did well to make 380 in the first innings, with skipper Michael Clarke contributing a hundred. In reply, we didn't start well, losing two quick wickets for 12 runs, and when I walked to the wicket we badly needed a partnership.

James Pattinson was bowling fast and I decided to take the battle to him and play my shots. The first ball was slightly wide of off stump and I presented the full face of the blade and was happy to see the ball race past the fielders to the boundary. I repeated the shot to the second ball and the result, to my delight, was the same. The final ball of the over was short of a length and I moved inside the line to flick it to fine leg for another four. I had hit three boundaries in four balls and the pressure had eased. My comeback had started well.

Cheteshwar Pujara, who batted sensibly for his 44, kept me company and I was unbeaten on 71 at the end of the second day, confident of kicking on and getting a big hundred. However, it didn't turn out that way as I was bowled for 81 by the off-spinner Nathan Lyon on the third morning with a ball that was slightly fuller in length than I expected. I had made up my mind to get to the pitch of the ball and hit it between midwicket and long on with the turn. It was only when I realized that the length was full that I quickly changed my shot and that was my downfall.

Thankfully, the dismissal did not affect the team's momentum, with Virat getting a hundred and Dhoni a blistering double hundred, one of the best innings I have seen at the Chepauk, to give us a lead of 192. Our spinners, led by Ashwin, then ran through the Australians in the second innings, leaving us needing just 50 to win the match. In my second innings, I played the same shot to Nathan Lyon's first two balls and on both occasions the ball flew between midwicket and long on for six and we soon closed out the match.